

RELIGION WITHOUT GOD

DEFINITION AND POSSIBILITY TEST → FOUR NEGATIVE POSITIONS → BUDDHISM → JAINISM, MĪMĀṂSĀ AND SĀṂKHYA → CĀRVĀKA AS LIMIT CASE → NIETZSCHE AND POST-THEISM

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g9 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 DEFINITION AND POSSIBILITY TEST

DEFINITION AND POSSIBILITY TEST CAN RELIGION EXIST WITHOUT A CREATOR GOD? RELIGION MAY ORGANISE ULTIMATE CONCERN SACRED VALUE MORAL DISCIPLINE WORLDVIEW THEISM IS SUFFICIENT FOR MANY RELIGIONS, NOT CONCEPTUALLY NECESSARY

ATHEISTIC; SILENCE, IRRELEVANCE AND DENIAL ARE DIFFERENT POSITIONS.

CAN RELIGION EXIST WITHOUT A CREATOR GOD?

religion may organise

ultimate concern

sacred value

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- CAN RELIGION EXIST WITHOUT A CREATOR GOD?
- religion may organise
- ultimate concern

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- sacred value
- moral discipline worldview
- THEISM is sufficient for many religions, not conceptually necessary for all test a tradition by doctrine + practice

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- + soteriology, not by a Western creator template
- TRAP: non-theistic != atheistic; silence, irrelevance and denial are different positions.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — non-theistic != atheistic; silence, irrelevance and denial are different positions.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: non-theistic != atheistic; silence, irrelevance and denial are different positions.

01

STAGE 01 FOUR NEGATIVE POSITIONS

FOUR NEGATIVE POSITIONS DENIES THAT GOD EXISTS SUSPENDS JUDGEMENT BECAUSE KNOWLEDGE/EVIDENCE IS INSUFFICIENT GOD IS ABSENT OR NON-CENTRAL TO THE PATH HOLDS GOD-BELIEF HARMFUL OR FALSE IN A STRONGER EVALUATIVE

"GOD" MUST BE MADE MEANINGFUL BEFORE EXISTENCE IS DEBATED LIFE ORGANISED WITHOUT REFERENCE TO GOD KEEP EPISTEMIC SUSPENSION

ATHEISM: denies that God exists

AGNOSTICISM: suspends judgement because knowledge/evidence is insufficient

NON-THEISM: God is absent or non-central to the path

ANTI-THEISM: holds God-belief harmful or false in a stronger evaluative sense

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- ATHEISM: denies that God exists
- AGNOSTICISM: suspends judgement because knowledge/evidence is insufficient

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- NON-THEISM: God is absent or non-central to the path
- ANTI-THEISM: holds God-belief harmful or false in a stronger evaluative sense

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- IGNOSTICISM: "God" must be made meaningful before existence is debated practical atheism: life organised without reference to God
- keep epistemic suspension separate from metaphysical denial.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — AGNOSTICISM: suspends judgement because knowledge/evidence is insufficient

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Agnosticism suspends judgement about God's existence or knowability; unlike atheism, it withholds assent rather than asserting denial.

02

STAGE 02 BUDDHISM

FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS DEPENDENT ORIGATION EIGHTFOLD PATH NIRVĀNA NO ETERNAL CREATOR IS NEEDED; SUFFERING HAS CONDITIONED BUDDHA REJECTS SPECULATIVE QUESTIONS WHEN THEY DO NOT CONDUCE KARMA/ORDER FUNCTIONS LIKE HIDDEN PROVIDENCE REPLY

CAUSAL-MORAL REGULARITY IS IMPERSONAL; NO OMNIPOTENT ALLOCATOR OR CREATOR

FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS → dependent origination → eightfold path → nirvāṇa no eternal creator is

suffering has conditioned causes, not divine decree devas may occur in cosmology but are impermanent

Buddha rejects speculative questions when they do not conduce to cessation of duḥkha objection: karma/order

no omnipotent allocator or creator follows.

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS → dependent origination → eightfold path → nirvāṇa no eternal creator is needed
- suffering has conditioned causes, not divine decree devas may occur in cosmology but are impermanent and

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- Buddha rejects speculative questions when they do not conduce to cessation of duḥkha objection: karma/order functions like hidden

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS → dependent origination → eightfold path → nirvāṇa no eternal creator is needed
- suffering has conditioned causes, not divine decree devas may occur in cosmology but are impermanent and

02

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- ATHEISM: denies that God exists
- AGNOSTICISM: suspends judgement because knowledge/evidence is insufficient

MECHANISM / VERDICT

AGNOSTICISM: suspends judgement because knowledge/evidence is insufficient

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Agnosticism suspends judgement about God's existence or knowability; unlike atheism, it withholds assent rather than asserting denial.

03

STAGE 02

BUDDHISM

FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS

DEPENDENT ORIGATION

EIGHTFOLD PATH

NIRVĀNA NO ETERNAL CREATOR IS NEEDED; SUFFERING HAS CONDITIONED

BUDDHA REJECTS SPECULATIVE QUESTIONS WHEN THEY DO NOT CONDUCE

KARMA/ORDER FUNCTIONS LIKE HIDDEN PROVIDENCE REPLY

CAUSAL-MORAL REGULARITY IS IMPERSONAL; NO OMNIPOTENT ALLOCATOR OR CREATOR

FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS → dependent origination → eightfold path → nirvāṇa no eternal creator is

→ suffering has conditioned causes, not divine decree devas may occur in cosmology but are impermanent → Buddha rejects speculative questions when they do not conduce to cessation of dukkha objection: karma/order → no omnipotent allocator or creator follows.

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS → dependent origination → eightfold path → nirvāṇa no eternal creator is needed
- suffering has conditioned causes, not divine decree devas may occur in cosmology but are impermanent and unsaving

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- Buddha rejects speculative questions when they do not conduce to cessation of dukkha objection: karma/order functions like hidden
- no omnipotent allocator or creator follows.

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS → dependent origination → eightfold path → nirvāṇa no eternal creator is needed
- suffering has conditioned causes, not divine decree devas may occur in cosmology but are impermanent and unsaving

MECHANISM / VERDICT

Dependent origination and karma (action and moral causation) make a creator explanatorily unnecessary, while ethics, meditation, community and nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) preserve a fully religious form of life.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Dependent origination and karma (action and moral causation) make a creator explanatorily unnecessary, while ethics, meditation, community and nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) preserve a fully religious form of life.

04

STAGE 03

JAINISM, MĪMĀṂSĀ AND SĀṂKHYA

JAINISM, MĪMĀṂSĀ AND SĀṂKHYA

ETERNAL JĪVA/AJĪVA; KARMIC MATTER; TĪRTHĀṆKARA TEACHES, NOT CREATES

AUTHORLESS ETERNAL VEDA; RITUAL ACTION GENERATES APŪRVA; NO DIVINE

PRAKṚTĪ EVOLVES FOR PLURAL PURUṢAS; UNCONSCIOUS TELEOLOGY WITHOUT CREATOR

IF GOD IS PERFECT, WHY CREATE? IF EMBODIED, WHO

JAINISM RETAINS WORSHIPFUL EXEMPLARS; MĪMĀṂSĀ CENTRES DHARMA/RITUAL

SĀṂKHYA CENTRES DISCRIMINATIVE METAPHYSICS AND KAIVALYA.

| SYSTEM / DOCTRINE                                                                         | DECISIVE DISTINCTION                                                                               | EVALUATION / TRAP                                        |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| JAINISM: eternal jīva/ajīva; karmic matter; tirthaṅkara teaches, not creates              | unconscious teleology without creator shared anti-creator pressure: if God is perfect, why create? | Sāṃkhya centres discriminative metaphysics and kaivalya. |
| MĪMĀṂSĀ: authorless eternal Veda; ritual action generates apūrva; no divine author needed | if embodied, who made body?                                                                        |                                                          |
| SĀṂKHYA: prakṛtī evolves for plural puruṣas                                               | distinctions: Jainism retains worshipful exemplars; Mīmāṃsā centres dharma/ritual                  |                                                          |

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

- JAINISM: eternal jīva/ajīva; karmic matter; tirthaṅkara teaches, not creates
- MĪMĀṂSĀ: authorless eternal Veda; ritual action generates apūrva; no divine author needed
- SĀṂKHYA: prakṛtī evolves for plural puruṣas

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- unconscious teleology without creator shared anti-creator pressure: if God is perfect, why create?
- if embodied, who made body?
- distinctions: Jainism retains worshipful exemplars; Mīmāṃsā centres dharma/ritual

EVALUATION / TRAP

- Sāṃkhya centres discriminative metaphysics and kaivalya.

MECHANISM / VERDICT

Jainism, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) show that liberation, scripture, ritual and cosmic explanation can be organised without a creator deity.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Jainism, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) show that liberation, scripture, ritual and cosmic explanation can be organised without a creator deity.

STAGE 04

CĀRVĀKA AS LIMIT CASE

CĀRVĀKA AS LIMIT CASE

CĀRVĀKA DENIES GOD, AFTERLIFE, KARMA, VEDIC AUTHORITY AND MOKṢA

DOES IT COUNT AS RELIGION?

DOCTRINAL-HISTORICAL MEMBER OF INDIAN PHILOSOPHICAL DEBATE

YES SACRED/TRANSCENDENT/SOTERIOLOGICAL PRACTICE IN ROBUST SENSE

LARGELY NO LIMIT CASE SHOWS THAT "PHILOSOPHY WITHOUT GOD"

BUDDHISM/JAINISM BETTER PRESERVE RITUAL, COMMUNITY AND LIBERATION FUNCTIONS.

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- CĀRVĀKA denies God, afterlife, karma, Vedic authority and mokṣa embodied this-worldly flourishing replaces salvation
- DOES IT COUNT AS RELIGION?

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- doctrinal-historical member of Indian philosophical debate: YES sacred/transcendent/soteriological practice in robust sense: largely NO limit case shows that
- "philosophy without God" is easier than "religion without God"

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- Buddhism/Jainism better preserve ritual, community and liberation functions.
- CĀRVĀKA denies God, afterlife, karma, Vedic authority and mokṣa embodied this-worldly flourishing replaces salvation

MECHANISM / VERDICT

Non-theistic traditions replace different divine functions separately—creation, authority, moral causation, worship or salvation—so 'religion without God' names several arguments rather than one model.

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04

MĪMĀMSĀ: authorless eternal Veda; ritual action generates apūrva; no divine author needed

SĀṂKHYA: prakṛti evolves for plural puruṣas

if embodied, who made body?

distinctions: Jainism retains worshipful exemplars; Mīmāṃsā centres dharma/ritual

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

- JAINISM: eternal jīva/ajīva; karmic matter; tīrthaṅkara teaches, not creates
- MĪMĀMSĀ: authorless eternal Veda; ritual action generates apūrva; no divine author needed
- SĀṂKHYA: prakṛti evolves for plural puruṣas

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- unconscious teleology without creator shared anti-creator pressure: if God is perfect, why create?
- if embodied, who made body?
- distinctions: Jainism retains worshipful exemplars; Mīmāṃsā centres dharma/ritual

EVALUATION / TRAP

- Sāṃkhya centres discriminative metaphysics and kaivalya.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Jainism, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) show that liberation, scripture, ritual and cosmic explanation can be organised without a creator deity.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Jainism, Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) and Sāṃkhya (enumeration-based dualist school) show that liberation, scripture, ritual and cosmic explanation can be organised without a creator deity.

05

STAGE 04

CĀRVĀKA AS LIMIT CASE

CĀRVĀKA AS LIMIT CASE

CĀRVĀKA DENIES GOD, AFTERLIFE, KARMA, VEDIC AUTHORITY AND MOKṢA

DOES IT COUNT AS RELIGION?

DOCTRINAL-HISTORICAL MEMBER OF INDIAN PHILOSOPHICAL DEBATE

YES SACRED/TRANSCENDENT/SOTERIOLOGICAL PRACTICE IN ROBUST SENSE

LARGELY NO LIMIT CASE SHOWS THAT “PHILOSOPHY WITHOUT GOD”

BUDDHISM/JAINISM BETTER PRESERVE RITUAL, COMMUNITY AND LIBERATION FUNCTIONS.

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- CĀRVĀKA denies God, afterlife, karma, Vedic authority and mokṣa embodied this-worldly flourishing replaces salvation
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ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

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IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- Buddhism/Jainism better preserve ritual, community and liberation functions.
- CĀRVĀKA denies God, afterlife, karma, Vedic authority and mokṣa embodied this-worldly flourishing replaces salvation

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Non-theistic traditions replace different divine functions separately—creation, authority, moral causation, worship or salvation—so ‘religion without God’ names several arguments rather than one model.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Non-theistic traditions replace different divine functions separately—creation, authority, moral causation, worship or salvation—so ‘religion without God’ names several arguments rather than one model.

06

STAGE 05

NIETZSCHE AND POST-THEISM

NIETZSCHE AND POST-THEISM

“GOD IS DEAD”

COLLAPSE OF THE CHRISTIAN-METAPHYSICAL VALUE HORIZON DANGER

NIHILISM, HERD MORALITY EXPOSED, NO TRANSCENDENT GUARANTOR TASK

REVALUATION OF VALUES

LIFE-AFFIRMATION NOT A SIMPLE EMPIRICAL PROOF THAT NO DEITY

SELF-CREATED VALUES RISK ARBITRARINESS OR DOMINATION REPLY

GENEALOGY TESTS INHERITED VALUES; AFFIRMATIVE CREATION ACCEPTS RESPONSIBILITY

“GOD IS DEAD” = collapse of the Christian-metaphysical value horizon danger: nihilism, herd morality exposed

→ affirmative creation accepts responsibility

→ POST-THEISM asks what religious depth survives after classical supernatural belief.

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- “GOD IS DEAD” = collapse of the Christian-metaphysical value horizon danger: nihilism, herd morality exposed, no transcendent guarantor
- affirmative creation accepts responsibility

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- POST-THEISM asks what religious depth survives after classical supernatural belief.
- “GOD IS DEAD” = collapse of the Christian-metaphysical value horizon danger: nihilism, herd morality exposed, no transcendent guarantor

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- affirmative creation accepts responsibility
- POST-THEISM asks what religious depth survives after classical supernatural belief.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Nietzsche’s ‘death of God’ is a diagnosis of the collapse of a value-horizon, not merely a proof of atheism; its unresolved task is the non-arbitrary revaluation of values.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Nietzsche’s ‘death of God’ is a diagnosis of the collapse of a value-horizon, not merely a proof of atheism; its unresolved task is the non-arbitrary revaluation of values.

STAGE 06

NATURALISM AND FICTIONALISM

NATURALISM AND FICTIONALISM

RELIGIOUS NATURALISM

NATURE IS ULTIMATE; AWE, GRATITUDE, RITUAL AND ETHICS WITHOUT

PARTICIPATE IN GOD-LANGUAGE/PRACTICE WITHOUT LITERAL ONTOLOGICAL ASSENT

SEA OF FAITH

RELIGIOUS SYMBOLS SHAPE LIFE RATHER THAN REPORT A TRANSCENDENT

WORSHIP WITHOUT REAL OBJECT IS MAKE-BELIEVE; PRAYER LOSES ADDRESS

SYMBOLS AND COMMUNAL NARRATIVES CAN DISCLOSE VALUE AND TRANSFORM

RELIGIOUS NATURALISM: nature is ultimate; awe, gratitude, ritual and ethics without supernaturalism

→ FICTIONALISM: participate in God-language/practice without literal ontological assent

→ SEA OF FAITH / non-realism: religious symbols shape life rather than report a transcendent entity

→ prayer loses address

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- RELIGIOUS NATURALISM: nature is ultimate; awe, gratitude, ritual and ethics without supernaturalism
- FICTIONALISM: participate in God-language/practice without literal ontological assent

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- SEA OF FAITH / non-realism: religious symbols shape life rather than report a transcendent entity objections: worship without
- prayer loses address

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- truth is sacrificed replies: symbols and communal narratives can disclose value and transform conduct pressure remains: can function
- RELIGIOUS NATURALISM: nature is ultimate; awe, gratitude, ritual and ethics without supernaturalism

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Religious naturalism retains ultimacy within nature, whereas religious fictionalism retains participation without literal assent; the decisive test is whether either preserves sincere transformation rather than mere aesthetics.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious naturalism retains ultimacy within nature, whereas religious fictionalism retains participation without literal assent; the decisive test is whether either preserves sincere transformation rather than mere aesthetics.

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exposed, no transcendent guarantee

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM:** Nietzsche's 'death of God' is a diagnosis of the collapse of a value-horizon, not merely a proof of atheism; its unresolved task is the non-arbitrary revaluation of values.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious naturalism retains ultimacy within nature, whereas religious fictionalism retains participation without literal assent; the decisive test is whether either preserves sincere transformation rather than mere aesthetics.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT BY CRITERION creator-belief necessary? NO | ultimate concern/ritual/transformation possible? YES personal worship and providence preserved? often NO.**

**OPTIONAL STATUS** — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.